partisan stand (like Pakistan), instead of engaging with all factions and convincing none. Ironically, even Karzai's advisors and spokespersons such as Waheed Omar, who engaged with India regularly, thought that New Delhi was either not committed towards Afghanistan (given its reluctance to support Karzai militarily) or was just confused.[66] Shivshankar Menon agrees about the limitations of the conciliatory approach.[67] Unlike the 1990s, when India was seen as supporting non-Pashtun interest groups over those from the Pashtun communities, the opposite perception of India being too pro-Pashtun developed after 2002. What conciliators thought as being state-to-state relations, were being viewed as a pro-Pashtun approach by Karzai's opponents. Such accusations of taking sides even if India just talked to different factions, Menon argued, were bound to occur in an ethnically divided country. 'We [India] used to be accused of this [taking sides] even in the 1940s and the 1950s. When we supported Badshah Khan and the Khudai Khidmatgars, we were told, "what is this, you rely on Pashtuns". And this is because of Congress Party's old links [but] how can it be that we don't do anything there [in Pashtun areas]', he asks rhetorically.[68]

India's initial SDPs, which were focused in south and east Afghanistan, had nurtured the perception that the Pashtuns were being favoured over other communities. The fact was that first round of SDPs were offered to communities who needed them most and were first off the block to ask for them. And all of them were from southern and eastern regions that were worst affected by the conflict. Handled by Afghans themselves (and not Indian personnel), each SDP cost a maximum of US$ 3 million, and was implemented without heavy bureaucratic clearances by central Afghan ministries where corrupt officials would ask for bribes. Given the popularity of these SDPs, not only did the Taliban never attack them, but they also came to appreciate India's people-friendly approach—further cementing the notion that India was pro-Pashtun.[69] India's attempts at spreading these SDPs across the country in central, north, and west Afghanistan did little to assuage such concerns, and were mostly seen as token projects. When quizzed about the political intent behind these SDPs, and their focus in Pashtun-dominated areas, Mukhopadhaya accepted that probably it is not wrong to say that India felt the need to compensate the Pashtuns more than other communities after 2002, and therefore it made extra effort to reach out to